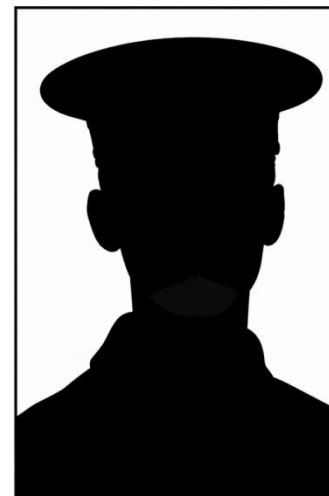




William “Willie” Oliver

1884 - 1916

Civilian Research

Field Name	Field Data	Source of data
Casualty Name	William Oliver	CWGC
Date of Birth	1884 Launceston, Cornwall Baptised 5/3/1884 Launceston	GRO 1911 Census Cornwall Online Parish Clerk index
Date of Death (from Spreadsheet)	18/11/1916 His regiment was in Ypres at the time of his death – he died after being hit by an railway engine that he stepped in front of – accidental see below.	CWGC Details below.
Age at death (from Spreadsheet)	33 Newspaper cutting says in his 32 nd year (ie	CWGC

	31) and students say 32	
Marital Status	I haven't found any reference but I haven't found an obituary either.	
Children (if any)		
Occupation prior to Call up	In 1911 William was working as a clerk at the National Bank, Camden Town, age 27	
Parents	George Massey Oliver and Annie Laura Simcoe Oliver, of "Dreaseon," 35a, Wellesley Road, Harrow, 1916	CWGC
Listed Address(s)	35a Wellesley Road, Harrow 4 Vaughan Road, Harrow on the Hill	1911 Census 1901 Census
Parents /Fathers occupation	Clerk - Jobbing	1911 Census
Brothers and Sisters	Arthur Oliver (younger), Jane Squire Oliver (younger), Reginald Oliver (younger)	1911 Census
Years at John Lyon School		
University (if any)		
Obituary	See below	
Additional sources of data		
War Memorials:	St Peter's Church, Sumner Rd, Harrow	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/249864
	Our Lady and St Thomas of Canterbury, Rosborough Park, Harrow Green	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/249974
	Harrow on the Hill war memorial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11092
	John Lyon School plaque	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11204
	John Lyon School sun dial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11318
	I would have thought there was a bank memorial somewhere	

Military research

JLS WWI RoH	OLIVER W.
CWGC Reference	https://www.cwgc.org/find-war-dead/casualty/138591/oliver,-william/
Age	33
DoD	18-Nov-16
Rank	Rfn
Regiment	London Regiment (London Irish Rifles) 1st/18th Bn
Organisations must have served or have members who served in the Ypres Salient or the Somme in World War One.	<u>VLAMERTINGHE MILITARY CEMETERY</u>
Location	West-Vlaanderen, Belgium
CWGC in process of uploading image of headstones which will give us his age, hopefully.	Son of George Massey Oliver and Annie Laura Simcoe Oliver, of "Dreason," 35a, Wellesley Road, Harrow, Middlesex. Rifleman William Oliver died on November 18, 1916, at the age of 33. He served with the 1st/18th Battalion of the London Regiment (London Irish Rifles). Rifleman William Oliver died on November 18, 1916 in Belgium from injuries sustained during active service. He served with the 1st/18th Battalion, London Regiment (London Irish Rifles) under service number 5077. Official military files list his manner of death as "Died" rather than "Killed in Action". In World War I record-keeping, this designation specifically meant he succumbed to illness, a non-combat accident, or a sudden medical emergency while on active service. He died in the Ypres Salient sector of Flanders, Belgium. He is buried at the Vlamertinghe Military Cemetery (Grave Reference: IV. K. 14), located just west of the town of Ypres (Ieper)

Story of Sacrifice

William Oliver (1884 – 1916)

William “Willie” Oliver worked as a bank clerk and was known for his artistic ability at John Lyon School, before enlisting in the London Irish Rifles during the First World War. He was killed in an accident near Poperinghe in October 1916, aged 32, when he was struck by a light railway engine while detraining.

Civilian Life

Willie Oliver was born in Launceston, Cornwall, in 1884, the eldest son of George Massey and Annie Laura Simcoe Oliver. While he was still young, the family settled in Harrow, where his father worked as a clerk. Willie attended The John Lyon School before beginning a career as a clerk with the National Bank at its Camden Town branch. Away from his professional work, he was remembered for an exceptional artistic ability. Former school records described him as "an inveterate sketcher" and noted that he was ambidextrous, a rare skill that enabled him to draw with either hand. Although no collection of his work is known to survive, this gift was one of the qualities for which he was remembered by those who knew him.

Military Life

When the First World War intervened, Willie exchanged the drawing pencil for a rifle. Enlisting as Rifleman 5077 in the 1st/18th Battalion, London Regiment (London Irish Rifles), he joined a battalion that, in October 1916, moved from the Somme to the Ypres Salient in Belgium. His time on the Western Front was remarkably brief. Contemporary reports record that he had been in France for only four days when, after his battalion had been relieved from the line and transported by rail in darkness and heavy rain, tragedy struck. While the men were detraining near Poperinghe, a light railway engine emerged unexpectedly. Despite warning shouts, Willie failed to clear the track in time and was struck and killed. His death occurred not in an attack or under enemy fire, but in an accident while on active service, bringing his military career to an abrupt end almost as soon as it had begun. He was buried in Vlamertinghe Military Cemetery near Ypres.

His father received a kind letter from the Rev. Father Pike saying: “I have buried your brave son in a beautifully kept Cemetery and gave him a Catholic burial and blessed his grave with many kind expressions of sympathy and deep regrets from his C.O. His commanding officer later wrote to his parents that he had always carried out every instruction faithfully and that he would be greatly missed by the battalion.

Notes and Clippings

Parents married in Bodmin, Jun Qtr 1883

https://www.gracesguide.co.uk/National_Bank info about the National Bank

Found his baptism on the Cornwall Online Parish Clerk:

- William Oliver son of George Massey Oliver and Annie Laura Simcoe Oliver, 5 Mar 1884, in the parish church at North Hill, Cornwall. Residence was Trebartha Village. His father was a gamekeeper.
- His birth was registered in the Launceston registration district in the Mar Qtr 1884

Reg number: 5077, London Regiment (London Irish Rifles) 1st/18th Bn

Movements of his regiment: from <https://www.londonirishrifles.com/index.php/first-world-war/war-diaries/war-diary-1-18th-london-regiment-november-1916/>

1/18th Battalion (Belgium)

- In October 1916, they moved from the muddy **Somme** battlefields to the Ypres sector in Belgium – so he did not die in the Somme offensive
- On 18 November, they were resting and training behind the front lines as part of the **2nd Army**. [[1](#), [2](#), [3](#), [4](#), [5](#)]

I can't find any info about how he died although one AI search came up with him being injured at Ypres and sent to a hospital where he succumbed to his wounds but no proof yet. Buried at Vlamertinghe Military Cemetery, Belgium. Another suggested he died after stepping off a train in Ypres and was hit by a train going in the opposite direction.

I found the train reference from the diaries of the London Irish but it states 22 November not 18 November as quoted by CWGC.

<https://www.londonirishrifles.com/index.php/first-world-war/in-the-line-october-1916-to-april-1917/>

“On the night of 22nd of November, in pouring rain, the Battalion was relieved by 22nd (Queens) and marched back to Ypres where they entrained for the 10 minute ride to Poperinghe. Whilst de-training Rfn William Oliver was killed when he stepped into the path of a light engine.”

And this as well which uses the 18 November as the date.

<https://www.londonirishrifles.com/index.php/first-world-war/1-18th-battalion-in-the-first-world-war/october-to-december-1916/>

“The London Irish were relieved by 22nd Battalion on the night of **18th November** and, in pitch darkness and pouring rain, moved back to Ypres. Following a ten minute ride on the railway, the troops de-trained in the vicinity of Poperinghe and, while de-training, the Battalion narrowly escaped disaster. A warning shout was heard and, almost before the men had time to jump clear of the permanent way, a light engine raced by in the darkness. **One man failed to get clear and was knocked down by the engine and killed.**”

1/12/1916 Harrow Observer

1/12/1916 Harrow Observer

RIFLEMAN W. OLIVER.

The news has been received that Rifleman "Willie" Oliver, London Irish Rifles, has died of wounds in France, on November 18, in his 32nd year. He was eldest son of Mr. and Mrs. Oliver of Wellesley-road. His father has received a kind letter from the Rev. Father Pike saying: "I have buried your brave son in a beautifully kept Cemetery and gave him a Catholic burial and blessed his grave with many kind expressions of sympathy and deep regrets from his C.O. Major Richardson, who added: "He always faithfully carried out all instructions given to him, I miss him so much." The gallant soldier, who was an Old Lyonian had only arrived in France four days before meeting with his death.

1/12/1916 Harrow Observer RIFLEMAN W. OLIVER.

The news has been received that Rifleman "Willie" Oliver, London Irish Rifles, has died of wounds in France, on November 18, in his 32nd year. He was eldest son of Mr. and Mrs. Oliver of Wellesley road. His father has received a kind letter from the Rev. Father Pike saying: "I have buried your brave son in a beautifully kept Cemetery and gave him a Catholic burial and blessed his grave with many kind expressions of sympathy and deep regrets from his C.O. Major Richardson, who added: "He always faithfully carried out all instructions given to him, I miss him so much." The gallant soldier, who was an Old Lyonian had only arrived in France four days before meeting with his death.

From the Centenary issue of the Lyonian, researched by pupils 2014	
Oliver, W Pte. W Oliver, London Irish Rifles, died at the age of 32. He was an inveterate sketcher, ambidextrous too. Question over age – see above in chart re age	From the Centenary issue of the Lyonian, researched by pupils 2014 Oliver, W Pte. W Oliver, London Irish Rifles, died at the age of 32. He was an inveterate sketcher, ambidextrous too.